

Session 3: The Shape of Biblical Literature

Key Takeaways

- The Bible is ancient Jewish meditation literature expertly crafted according to a set of design conventions that are unfamiliar to most modern readers.
- The biblical authors build connections and add layers of meaning by crafting this literature in sets (most commonly, sets of three) so that we can compare and contrast the different sections of each set and link to others.
- The intricate design of biblical literature invites us to slow down and meditate on its meaning, allowing it to shape us over a lifetime.

The Literary Design of Genesis 1-50

Movement 1—Genesis 1:1-11:26

From Adam to Noah to His 70 Descendants

1:1-5:32

Humanity = The exalted image of Elohim; Exile and death of the chosen

6:1-9:17

God brings a flood of justice, but saves a righteous remnant

9:18-11:26

Brothers divide after the flood

Movement 2—Genesis 11:27-25:18

From Abraham to Isaac

11:27-19:38

God chooses the younger son for blessing and covenant

20:1-22:19

God requires and gives back the life of the chosen son

22:20-25:18

Death, blessing, and the separation of the brothers

Movement 3—Genesis 25:19-37:1

From Isaac to Jacob

25:19-28:9

God chooses the younger son for blessing and covenant

28:10-31:52

God requires and gives back the life of the chosen son

32:1-37:1

Near-death, blessing, and the separation of the brothers

Movement 4—Genesis 37:2-50:26

From Jacob to His 12 Sons and 70 Descendants

37:2-41:57

Yoseph = The exalted image of Pharaoh; Exile and death of the chosen

42:1-45:25a

God brings a flood of famine, but saves a remnant

45:25b-50:26

Brothers are reconciled after the famine

Genesis 1-50. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

While every part of the Genesis scroll is patterned after earlier parts, there is a network of vocabulary and themes that are shared between these four larger movements that indicate a large-scale symmetrical arrangement.

The Key Design Conventions in Biblical Literature

What is the unique literary style of communication used by the biblical authors?

The key is found in the first literary unit of the Hebrew Bible (Gen. 1:1-2:3).

But before we go there, we need to remind ourselves of some of the basic categories of symmetry and design that we find in Hebrew poetry. These provide us with the basic axioms of biblical literature in general.

The work of the “Texture Seminar” scholars is foundational here.

- David Andrew Teeter, in his essay, “[Biblical Symmetry and Its Modern Detractors](#),” a paper delivered at the 2019 International Organization for the Study of the Old Testament.
- David Andrew Teeter and William Tooman, “[Standards of \(In\)coherence in Ancient Jewish Literature](#),” in Hebrew Bible and Ancient Israel, vol. 9 (2020), pp. 94-125.

But first, an aside on “analogical cognition.”

- Human cognition is built on a learned process of grouping, comparing, and contrasting all the sensory input that comes our way.
- This is like that, that is like this // This is not like that, that is not like this
- One of the most basic ways to present a meaningful comparison or contrast is to place two or three things next to each other and meditate on their similarities or differences.

For example, my wife has grouped three plants together on an old radio that we use as a decorative shelf by our dinner table.



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The unique features of each plant become more prominent only once we compare and contrast them to each other.

- All three are green.
- 1 and 2 have tan pots; 3 has a cream pot.
- 1 and 3 are big; 2 is small.
- 1 and 3 are elevated; 2 is not.
- 2 and 3 have thicker, rounded leaves; 1 does not.
- 1 and 3 have light and dark green leaves; 2 has mainly dark leaves.

The arrangement’s aesthetic effect depends on the viewer’s ability to compare and contrast the relationships between the various plants. The more we meditate on these relationships, the deeper the insight we gain into each.

The point: The arrangement of the plants is intentional, symmetrical, and invites the viewer to discover deeper layers of insight into all three plants by comparing and contrasting them with one another. Biblical

literature is built on this basic of principle.

Genesis 1:1-2:3 is entirely organized by this principle on every level of scale, from the smallest level of the line and arrangement of sentences into paragraphs, up to the largest levels of literary units, sections, parts, and movements that make up the scroll.

This design structure has arranged Genesis 1:1-2 into three parts, the center panel having two lines. Repeated words link every part together into a network of pairs and symmetries that lead the reader into meditation on their relationships.

1. Lines 1 and 2 mention “the land” but with different nuances of meaning.
 - Line 1 “land” is used in the phrase “skies and land.” // Line 2 “land” refers to the potential of land that is underneath the chaos waters.
2. Line 2 consists of two lines that pair together a variety of negative, pre-creation images.
 - “wild and waste” = a desert wasteland
 - “darkness” = the absence of light
 - “the deep” = the abysmal chaos waters
3. Lines 2 and 3 both mention “the waters,” but with different words.
 - Line 2: “the deep” = the uncontrolled, waters of chaos
 - Line 3: “the waters” = the neutral waters under the influence of the Spirit of Elohim
4. Lines 1 and 3 both mention Elohim in two related ways, as creator and as order-bringing Spirit.

The Function of Repetition and Symmetrical-Poetic Expression

This “speaking in pairs” creates opportunities to use multiple words and images to communicate one core idea from many angles. This type of poetic style is a wonderful way to express complex thoughts through pairing words or images in order to communicate more by means of the juxtaposition.

The biblical authors developed vocabulary for this technique called *mashal*.

Hebrew *mashal* (משל): comparison, analogy, proverb.

“The parallel lines of biblical poetry are like a pair of binoculars. Some centuries ago, the lenses of a field glass were set in cylinders that could be slid in and out, but they remained in a single tube. The lookout on a ship looked through it with one eye. Today’s field glass is a binocular: we look through two cylinders, with both eyes, so that we have the advantage of seeing depth. Our eyes, with or without binoculars, see ‘in stereo.’ The effect results from the fact that one eye has a slightly different angle than the other, and so produces a minimally different image. These two pictures are easily superimposed and assembled into one image inside our brain. Biblical parallelism does something comparable: this poetic device creates two subtly different images with two lines that are to be associated through parallel expression. It allows us an opportunity to consider both pictures separately, and then let them sink in together ... The point of similarity between two parallel lines is their very difference! Only those who look closely and have patience will discover and savor the role played by dissimilarity, its surprises, and its richness of meaning.”

Fokkelman, J.P. (2001). [*Reading Biblical Poetry*](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 78-79.

Reflection Question

How does tracing the literary design of the Bible help us better meditate on its meaning?